

CONVERSATION STARTERS FOR COUPLES

BY JOMO AND CHARMAINE COUSINS



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One of the most common recurring issues a couple can face is how to start a conversation and keep it flowing naturally. If you're just starting out in your relationship, you might be struggling to think of things to discuss that aren't too personal or off-topic. If you and your partner are married or have been together for a long time, you've likely exhausted most conversation topics and have nothing else to talk about!

It also doesn't help if you're shy or have social anxiety, where a conversation can feel like a job interview that you need to ace. Fortunately, though, it's a lot less formal than that, and there are plenty of tips and starters you can utilize to help you and your partner start talking. From simple topics about date preferences to personal discussions about your deepest selves, there are endless questions to start with and get the words flowing.

Tips for Having a Great Conversation

Write down your questions beforehand. You don't need to bring the list with you but writing it down can help you remember them when the time comes. Or, conversely, you can slap it on the table with a joke about your conversation skills. Oftentimes, people actually appreciate this kind of honesty and will happily look over the list and naturally generate a conversation based on it.

Consider the situation, mood, and environment you're in when forming questions. All these factors can significantly influence the way a conversation goes. If your partner approaches you with an angry or frustrated expression, you may want to ask what happened rather than what kind of buffet they would be.

Remember: good communication isn't about asking and answering a question. It's about building intimacy, common ground, trust, appreciation, respect, and so much more. Think about the way your partner answers the questions and/or whether it matches what they actually do when putting it into practice.

TOP 10 CONVERSATION STARTERS

Below you'll find a list of 10 top conversation starters you can ask your partner, including how your relationship can benefit from them, topics you can segue into afterward, and the ideal settings to ask them in. Some questions are deep, others are lighthearted, and a few depend on the level of your relationship.

Regardless of the question, however, remember that conversations are a two-way street. If you ask them a question and they freely answer, they will appreciate it tenfold if you also answer the question yourself. Exchanging ideas and views together makes for a successful conversation!

1. What's your story?

Best for new couples still learning about each other, this question can be answered as shallowly or deeply as they prefer. Depending on the information they offer, it gives you an idea of how open they are with others, any conflict of interests, and whether they seem like they'll be a good fit as your partner.

Segue Topics

This is very dependent on what they say. Listen to their story and find topics they mention that you can ask further about, such as family, friends, jobs, hobbies, or even previous romantic relationships.

Ideal Settings

First date

Having dinner together

Long walks

2. What was it like when you first met me? / What was the first thing you noticed when we met?

Whichever question you ask, they both help you understand what things your partner typically looks for first in a person, how you might appear to others in general, and how your partner expresses their feelings and emotions.

Segue Topics

Why did you feel that way? / Why did you notice that thing first?

Have you felt that way before?

Do I fit your “type”?

Ideal Settings

Dinner date

Casual settings

Pillow talk

3. What would you rather do for a date night: go to a fancy dinner or attend a cooking class to teach us how to make a fancy dinner?

This one helps you find out the kind of person that they are, such as whether they prefer the convenience and luxury experience of being served food, or whether they prefer hands-on experiences, doing things themselves, and learning new things. This is also great for getting an idea of what types of dates they might prefer in the future.

Segue Topics

What kinds of food do you like?

Are there some foods that you’d rather have someone else make instead of yourself?

Are there some foods that you’d rather make yourself instead of having in a restaurant?

Ideal Settings

Text/call conversations

Casual settings

Having dinner together

4. How would you describe the best version of yourself

This question has the potential to go quite deep depending on their answer. From what they say, you can glean the way they view themselves, the flaws they believe they have, their aspirations and goals, and the kind of lifestyle/direction they want to pursue in the future. This question is also great for long-term or married couples.

Segue Topics

Pick out anything notable from what they say and ask them why they think it would make them a better version of themselves.

Are you doing or planning anything to help you achieve that version of yourself?

Ideal Settings

Dinner date

Late-night conversations

Long walks

5. What question do you most want an answer to?

This is a perfect starter because the way the conversation goes is entirely dictated by your partner's answer. They can either answer it shallowly with a joke or something simple, or they can go a deeper route that explores philosophy, potential trauma, relationships, or more. It gives you an understanding of what might often be on their mind or a problem they're currently dealing with.

Segue Topics

If their answer is simpler, such as a problem at work they're dealing with, you can ask them about what happened and why it's their most significant question.

If their answer is deeper, you can share your own personal insights and views relevant to what they say.

Ideal Settings

Dinner date

Late-night conversations

Quiet car rides

6. Are there any moments where you've felt respected or disrespected by me?

Every couple should talk about the way they interact with each other – especially if one or the other is feeling disrespected. Asking this type of question will foster a stronger relationship based on healthy communication and can help you understand things you might be doing or saying to them without realizing their negative impact and how you should act going forward. If their answer is about something positive, then it lets you know what you're doing right and that you should keep it up. You may also be inclined to answer this question yourself about them.

Segue Topics

Why did you feel respected/disrespected?

If their answer is about something negative, ask them what you should or shouldn't do/say in a similar situation in the future.

Ideal Settings

At home

7. Do you feel like you have the freedom to be yourself in our relationship?

While this is perhaps one of the more unique and less asked questions, don't underestimate how powerful it can be in longer-term relationships. This question can open up a wealth of information and topics to explore depending on their answer, and it's a crucial question to ask so that you know their thoughts on where your relationship is going, if they have any worries, fears, or concerns, and if there are any glaring issues in the relationship that you may have been unaware of. A strong and healthy relationship involves two people who can comfortably be themselves around each other without fear of judgment or consequence. If your partner expresses feelings of the opposite, then you'll be able to discuss how to resolve things.

Segue Topics

If they say yes, ask what things they do/say around you that they wouldn't normally do around others.

If they say no, ask what is it that you do/say that makes them feel uncomfortable to be themselves.

Ideal Settings

At home

Late-night conversations

8. If you were to run your own business, what would it be?

A more casual topic – this question helps you gain an idea of the kind of person they are. Depending on their answer, you can find out if that's already a goal of theirs, how resourceful they are, if they like to plan things, what kinds of things they like, their views on business and economy, and other characteristics/traits they might have.

Segue Topics

Why would you choose to run that business?

How would you run it?

Would you want to establish multiple chains/locations?

Ideal Settings

Dates

Casual settings

Car rides

Long walks

9. What do you think are the most important traits for a parent to have?

Best for couples who already have or are discussing having children together. It's a great way to find out what values your partner has or wants to instill in their kids, what kind of parent they aspire to be, and what they might expect from you as a parent.

Segue Topics

What are the worst traits a parent can have?

What parenting style would you want to use?

What are your thoughts on disciplining them?

Ideal Settings

At home

Dinner date

10. In a zombie apocalypse, what are 3 rules you'd follow to survive?

For couples who enjoy talking about weird things and fantasy situations. This question allows for more light-hearted conversation that doesn't put pressure on how your partner responds. Being able to laugh with each other and discuss "weird" things helps you bond, reduces stress, and gives you an idea of how open they are to talking about these kinds of things.

Segue Topics

If you started out with only one item during a zombie apocalypse, what would you choose?

"Weird" conversations involving dystopian situations, conspiracy theories, your favorite zombie movies, etc.

Ideal Settings

Dates

Car rides

Casual settings

Text/call conversations

HOW TO START A DIFFICULT CONVERSATION

It's inevitable that, at some point in your relationship, you will be faced with a difficult conversation that you must undergo with your partner. When that time comes, it can be so stressful that you end up just avoiding it altogether. However, that's probably one of the worst things you can do and can have worse impacts on your relationship than if you had just had the conversation in the first place.

If you need to have a hard conversation with your partner, here are some tips for you to follow:

Don't preface with the word "but"

You may be inclined to give the good news before the bad news, but sometimes it causes more stress if you say, "I love your cooking but the chili was too salty." Getting the bad news out of the way first by saying, "I thought the chili was a bit salty, but it was overall very delicious" helps soften the blow.

Don't hold in your feelings

More often than not, people hold in their negative emotions until "the right time" to discuss them. Then, when that time never comes, they explode over the smallest slight and make the situation much worse than it should have been. Don't avoid having the conversation until it's too late.

Use gentle wording

When discussing difficult topics, it's important not to use harsh or accusatory language. This just paves the way for an unnecessary argument. For example, instead of saying, "I'd like to talk about how we never have sex" you can instead say, "I'd like to talk about my feelings about how often we have sex." At this point, you can also plan a time to discuss the topic where you'll both be prepared for it.

Be optimistic

Having difficult conversations is a natural part of every relationship, so it's important to stay optimistic about what your partner says and the outcome of the discussion. If you go into the conversation with a negative outlook or pessimism, then that's all you will see. Make sure that you and your partner know that you're both in this together.

Conclusion

Hopefully, these tips and starters will help revitalize the flow of conversations you have with your partner and pave the way for more natural discussions in the future. When using any starter, whether from this list or somewhere else, it's important to know that they can only take you so far in a conversation.

Within a single person resides a wealth of conversation topics, such as their background, childhood, family, friends, languages, hobbies, likes, dislikes, jobs, life experiences, and so much more. Even if you've known your partner for a long time, they may still surprise you! All you really need to do is pay attention to what they say, ask about things that stand out to you, and go with the flow.

ABOUT JOMO AND CHARMAINE COUSINS

Dr. Jomo and Dr. Charmaine are Senior Pastors at Love First Christian Center in Riverview, FL. They have been married for 24 years and have three lovely children. Their goal is to create a community of people who aspire to enjoy life together as a couple. With a strong foundation in Christ, they hope to inspire and motivate those who may need a little guidance on their journey.

Jomo and Charmaine have had an amazing impact on not only the church family, but also the community at large. They have dedicated their time and knowledge in order to support the growth of others. There are so many things life throws at you as a couple. It's important to cultivate and develop your relationship so you don't allow life to get in the way and cause division between you. They don't claim to be perfect, but their hope is that through sharing what they've experienced as a couple and what they've learned counseling 1000's of couples over the years is that they can offer tips and advice to help you and your partner thrive as a couple.

Whether you are experiencing challenges with communication, sex, trust, or just want to give your relationship some much needed attention to ensure you are both in a good place, let Jomo and Charmaine help. Visit www.jomoandcharmaine.com to get in touch today.